

ECHOES OF HAVENBAY

The three candidates for Episode 1

Ally Quinn: True Crime Merge · Reading pack, 2026-08-24 · Indigo Chimp Studios

How to read this

Three murder-led stories are competing to open the game. One of them will be built. The other two go into the bank as later episodes, except that two of them share a spine and cannot both exist, so choosing badly costs more than a decision.

The pack is in two halves.

The first half is three pages, one per story. Each is headed by the case for that story as the pilot, followed by the logline, the first sixty seconds as they would be read aloud, and the honest catch. If you read nothing else, read those three pages. They are written to be read cold, and they are written to argue.

The second half is the three stories in full: what actually happened, who did it, how the player uncovers it, what they decide along the way, how it ends, and what each story does not have yet. That last part is deliberate and it is not padding. Each story is missing different things, and what a story is missing tells you as much as what it has.

What is not in here. No scores. An internal rubric rated the previous pilot near-perfect a week before twelve of twelve testers abandoned it, and then rated three replacement stories at ninety-four, ninety-two and ninety-four per cent, which separates nothing. This pack ranks and argues instead. The full analysis, the decision maps and the forced rankings live in [episode-1-pitches-v3.2](#).

What decides it. Not this document. Five or more of the twelve testers hear the three openings read aloud, blind, in a rotated order, and answer two questions: which one do you need to hear the rest of, and would you come back tomorrow for it.

PART ONE — THE CASE FOR EACH

The Confession

Why this should be Episode 1. The game spends its first ninety seconds teaching the player to trust an old man's judgement. Gerald's face fronts every hint, every banner, every help card. This is the episode where that man's back booth becomes a crime scene and his handwriting becomes the only surviving record of a murder confession, which makes him the last living witness and the next name on a list. No other candidate turns the tutorial into the stakes. It is also the cheapest of the three to build, the only one whose crime scene is a room the player has already been taught in, and the only one where the season's conspiracy arrives as an economy rather than as a coin: somebody was paid, thirty-seven years ago, and somebody has been paying ever since.

Logline. An eighty-one-year-old man confesses to a thirty-seven-year-old killing in the back booth of the Rusty Anchor, and by morning he is dead of a heart attack the medical examiner can prove was murder. Whoever silenced him waited thirty-seven years for him to talk. They were still listening. And the booth he talked in belongs to the man teaching Ally everything she knows.

The first sixty seconds.

ANNOUNCER (flat, synthetic): Message received: Saturday, eleven fifty-one p.m.

A WOMAN (*a voicemail, low, the bar noise gone from behind her*): It's me, my lovely. Not an emergency. Except I think it might be. There's a man in your grandad's booth who's been nursing one whiskey for four hours, and he's just told him something I wish I hadn't heard. Your grandad's writing it down. Come tonight.

ALLY (*on-mic*): By the time I got there, the man was gone. My grandad was still in the booth. He hadn't touched his glass.

He slid his notebook across the table and said: read it twice, love. Because tomorrow he'll deny it, and by Monday he'll be dead.

He was wrong about one thing.

The man in the booth didn't live until Monday.

The case in one paragraph. In 1989 a foundry foreman named Frank Doyle killed a man called Wren Kellaway and staged it as a drunken fall into the harbour. Kellaway was written off as a drunk. His younger sister June has spent thirty-seven years being told her brother drowned in shame, and has paid the mooring fee on his ruined dinghy every year since. Doyle's confession adds the thing 1989 could not: he was paid to make it look that way. He never saw the payer's face. He got a voice, an envelope, and a coin he never dared spend. Within hours of finally saying it out loud, Doyle is dead. Solving 1989 is how Ally works out who needed it silenced tonight.

Why it works as a pilot. The murder is on the page in the first minute. The victim is grievable in one detail, a biscuit tin with thirty-seven receipts in it: you don't keep a boat for a drunk, you keep a boat for a sailor. At the midpoint the episode stops being an investigation and becomes a protection detail, which changes what the player actually does. And every decision in it is the same question wearing a different coat: who do you trust with this. A page. A truth. A grandfather. A tape. A coin.

The catch, stated plainly. Its whole revival rests on an assumption nobody has tested: that ninety seconds of tutorial hint chips carrying Gerald's portrait produces *attachment* rather than mere *recognition*. If a cold

listener does not care about the grandad in that voicemail, the episode's engine is missing. The table-read tests exactly this, by asking each listener afterwards who they would least like to see get hurt.

The Overnight Girl

Why this should be Episode 1. Twelve testers said the last pilot was too safe and had no jeopardy. This is the answer to that sentence. A twelve-year-old boy telephones a stranger at three in the morning because his sister's phone rang once instead of twice, which is the signal they agreed on when he was small, and the signal means run. It has the clearest clock of the three, the cheapest decision design in the slate, and the only ending in this document that the player earns rather than picks: whether Ally reaches the boathouse first, arrives during, or arrives to find a woman who saved herself, is decided by how much the player got done. It also shares nothing with the story that failed, which means it can be built without inheriting a single assumption that has already been disproved.

Logline. Nina Vasquez, twenty-four, works the overnight counter at a harbour diner. Every night at ten past three she rings her kid brother twice and hangs up: the all-safe. Tonight the phone rang once. Four hours earlier, through the diner window, she watched two men load something man-shaped into the fish-market ice store. Nina is not missing. Nina is hiding. And the man looking for her has done this before.

The first sixty seconds.

ANNOUNCER (flat, synthetic): Message received: Thursday, three twelve a.m.

A BOY (*young, steady the way children are when they have rehearsed being brave*): My sister rings twice every night. Two rings means safe.

It rang once tonight.

She made me learn this number in case it ever rang once. She said ask for Ally. She said say the diner, say the ice store, say run.

ALLY (*on-mic*): He recited it like a times table. Somebody taught a twelve-year-old to be a dead man's switch.

That somebody is out there right now, with a head start measured in hours.

And so is whoever she built the switch against.

The case in one paragraph. There is a body in the ice store: a harbour customs clerk who had started photographing manifests he was not supposed to photograph. Nina saw the disposal, understood in about four seconds what having seen it meant, and executed an escape plan she has been rehearsing since she was nine years old, because her family ran from something once before and she has never assumed they were finished. She is not a victim waiting to be found. She is the most competent person in the episode, and she has left a trail only a person who listens to the show could follow. Someone else is following it too. He is patient, he is polite, he pays exact change, and he is a day ahead.

Why it works as a pilot. The jeopardy needs no explaining: a hunter is working through a list of everyone a frightened woman ever trusted, one conversation at a time. The player feels the clock because the hunter moves when they move. Three times in the episode two doors are open and there is time for one, and the door

not taken becomes a card on the evidence board reading *he got here first*. That is the cheapest agency in the slate and the only kind that accumulates into an ending.

The catch, stated plainly. It is the least Havenbay of the three. Strip the city out and the story survives, which is exactly what a good case should not do. It is also the heaviest to build: Nina needs a full character sheet because she survives into the series, and so do the hunter, the boy and the dead man's widow.

The Last Caller

Why this should be Episode 1. It contains the best sixty seconds anyone has written for this project. An old man rings a tip line at four minutes past midnight to confess a murder, gets as far as the witness's name, and a hand comes over the receiver. Four seconds of a room with two people breathing in it. Then dial tone. Somebody was standing there letting a dying man have his conscience, and stopped him at the only sentence that mattered. It turns the show's own craft into the murder weapon, it gives the player a woman to find who does not know she is being looked for, and it hands Episode 2 the most Ferryman-shaped fact in the slate.

Logline. The tip line's midnight message is a confession: an old man, naming a killing from decades ago, talking like a man out of time. The message cuts off mid-sentence. Not hung up. Interrupted. By morning there is a body, and the only person who can finish the dead man's sentence is the witness he was about to name, who has just stopped answering her phone.

The first sixty seconds.

ANNOUNCER (flat, synthetic): Message received: Wednesday, twelve oh four a.m.

A CALLER (elderly, deliberate, reading from something he has written down): My name doesn't matter yet. Write this down instead.

In August of nineteen eighty-nine a man went into the harbour at the foundry basin and it was called a fall. It was not a fall. I was paid to say it was.

The one who paid me had a voice I will hear when I die, which I am told is soon, so I am spending it.

There was a witness. She was nine years old. Her name is...

[The line does not click. It muffles: a hand over a receiver. Four seconds of a room with two people breathing in it. Then dial tone.]

ALLY (on-mic): The tip line keeps voices, timestamps and nothing else. That has always been the promise. Tonight I would trade the whole archive for one more second of tape.

Somewhere in this city is a woman who watched a murder when she was nine years old.

Two people are looking for her tonight.

I am the slower one.

The case in one paragraph. Nobody knows who the caller was. He is a voice, a room, and a medication bottle rattling somewhere off-microphone. Ally identifies him the only way she can, out of the recording itself: the interval of a foghorn, the rattle of a particular prescription, the shape of the room around him. By then he is dead of a murder the medical examiner can prove. Then the episode becomes a hunt for a woman in her

mid-forties who saw something when she was nine and has never told anybody, and who is now being looked for by the person who was standing next to a dying man at four minutes past midnight.

Why it works as a pilot. The dread arrives wordlessly, and wordless dread is the one thing our own testers responded to before the rest of the episode let them down. The victim who matters most does not know she is a victim. And the player is doing forensics on a recording, which is exactly what the merge board is good at: what they physically reconstruct is the investigation.

The catch, stated plainly. Two catches. It is the most expensive to branch, and the fix costs it its best scene. And structurally it is the closest of the three to the episode that failed: an interrupted recording is reconstructed in order to find a woman. A murder in the first minute changes the stakes and does not change the shape.

PART TWO — THE STORIES IN FULL

STORY ONE — "The Confession"

Seventeen leads across three phases · day-stamped clock, Saturday night through the following week · lightest art bill of the three

What actually happened

In August 1989, Wren Kellaway went into the harbour at the foundry basin. The city called it a fall. He had been drinking, the water was cold, the tide did the rest, and a man who worked nights at the foundry told the inquest he had seen him stumble.

That man was Frank Doyle, and he was lying, and he had been paid to lie.

Doyle never learned who paid him. He was given a voice on a telephone, an envelope of cash, and, tucked in his coat pocket afterwards where he had not put it, a brass coin with one face worn blank and a crescent nick in the rim. He kept the coin for thirty-seven years and never dared spend it.

Kellaway's younger sister June was told her brother drowned drunk and ashamed. She did not believe it and could not disprove it, so she did the only thing available to her: she kept paying the mooring fee on his ruined dinghy, every year, for thirty-seven years, and put the receipts in a biscuit tin.

Doyle is eighty-one and dying, and a dying man's conscience is a clock that somebody else has been watching.

Phase one — the confession and the body

The voicemail brings Ally to an empty booth and a full glass. Gerald slides his notebook across the table: he has written down everything the man said, in his own hand, because forty years of policing taught him what to write down and when to shut up.

The player's first decision comes almost immediately. The notebook page is either evidence or it is Ally's. Hand it to Del now and the chain of custody holds, the medical examiner enters the story a lead earlier, and the case is built the way a case is supposed to be built. Keep it and transcribe it yourself first, and the audio work turns up a detail the police route never gets: the *voice*, the thing Doyle remembered best about the man who paid him.

By morning Doyle is dead in a bedsit above a chandlery. Tidy heart attack, eighty-one years old, nobody's fault. Dr. Cortez finds the injection site behind the knee.

Ally rebuilds Doyle's last four hours from the things a bar remembers without meaning to: the till roll, the jukebox log, one whiskey that was never refilled. Somebody else was in the room. Somebody heard.

Then 1989 comes up out of the archive, and with it a woman who has been waiting thirty-seven years for someone to ask.

The second decision is what to do with her. Tell June Kellaway what Doyle confessed before there is any proof of it, and she becomes an active participant: the biscuit tin arrives, the receipts become evidence, and a whole obstacle in the second phase disappears. Hold it until it can be proved, and the same receipts have to be prised out of the harbour office instead, which costs a search warrant out of the case kit, and June's eventual testimony is unshakeable because she was never told a story she had to take on faith.

Phase one closes on the podcast: a man confessed to a murder and died before morning, and this show is going to find out what he confessed to.

Phase two — 1989 exhumed

The foundry is a ruin now, but night-shift records survive, and so do the men who worked them. Doyle's envelope is traced as far as an envelope can be traced. The coin surfaces, wrapped inside the confession page Gerald tore out.

A pale sedan parks across the road from the Rusty Anchor two nights running.

The third decision is how to find out who is in it. Run the plate through Del, which is lawful, slow, and leaves a record. Have Vega pull the paperwork of the dissolved company the plate traces to, which is fast and will not be admissible. Or put a callout on the tip line asking whether anybody knows who owns a pale sedan on Harbour Row, which is the loudest option and tells the man in the car that he has been seen.

The third option changes the shape of the rest of the episode. It brings the watcher's next move forward, so the final phase begins early, short, and under pressure, with Ally forced to protect before she is ready.

Because at the midpoint the case turns over. Gerald's notebook is the only surviving record of what Frank Doyle said. Which makes Gerald the only surviving witness to a confession somebody killed a man to stop. The question stops being who killed Doyle and becomes how do I keep my grandfather alive.

The fourth decision is where Gerald sleeps. Mo's back room is safest, and it closes the Rusty Anchor to Ally as a place to work for two leads, which changes what she can get done and what the board can supply. His own house, with Del's drive-bys, keeps the bar open and gets his back door forced while he is out, destroying a piece of evidence that would have made the final phase easier. The studio keeps everything and moves the taunting message on the tip line a day earlier, which unsettles the ending.

Phase three — the shield and the catch

Gerald recorded the confession. He is a careful man and he was a careful policeman.

The fifth decision is the one the episode is named for. Air it, and the whole city becomes a witness, which makes killing Gerald pointless because the secret is already out. The tip line floods, listeners start supplying evidence faster than Ally can process it, the subscriber count climbs, and June Kellaway hears her brother's murder as content before she hears it as truth. Or seal it, let Del work the injection site quietly, keep Gerald at Mo's, and accept that the killer's name will take two days longer to surface, which is two days in which a second grave is very nearly needed.

Both roads reach the same place, because both are walked on the mooring receipts. The man who put a needle behind Frank Doyle's knee is arrested. He is a proxy: he was hired, thirty-seven years ago, to watch one man and wait.

The paymaster is a name on paperwork that dissolved in the 1980s.

The last decision is the smallest and it costs nothing to build. Doyle's coin, still unspent. Keep it, and it goes on Ally's board and travels into the next episode, which starts one step further along. Log it into evidence with Del, and Havenbay PD have it, so getting it back is a whole extra lead next episode, but Del owes Ally a favour she will not have to ask twice for.

How it ends

June Kellaway gets a sentence she has waited thirty-seven years for, and the version she gets depends on what the player did. If she was told early she has had three days to be furious with a dead man and is steadier for it. If she was made to wait she says she would have liked those three days.

Ally closes the episode. Then the tip line takes one more message.

ANNOUNCER: Message received: Sunday, one a.m.

[Coins dropping into a payphone. Then a voice, elderly, unhurried.]

Frank always was sentimental. Goodnight, Miss Quinn.

[Click.]

What it costs

Ally, Gerald, Mo, Del and the Tip Line all exist on final art. Dr. Cortez needs a portrait: he is written into the roster but has never been drawn. June Kellaway is new and episode-level. Frank Doyle is never seen at all, only heard, plus one photograph on the evidence board, which is both the cheapest possible victim and the right one, because the whole episode is about a man who exists as a voice and a page. Two new backgrounds: the foundry ruin and June's kitchen. Everything else is reused. **Lightest art bill in the pack.**

The board work leans on audio (the tape, the jukebox log), forensics (the injection site, the exhumed file), the Rusty Anchor family, which finally gets a story that needs it, and food, for the wake and the interviews.

What this story does not have yet

- **Nobody is named as having benefited.** The proxy is caught. The paymaster is a dissolved company. Nobody in the episode is visibly getting away with something the player can point at, which is uncomfortably close to the complaint that started all this. It needs to name who profited from Wren Kellaway's death and who has been paying for quiet ever since.
 - **There is nothing Ally believes and has to abandon.** No wrong turn, no theory that collapses, so the player never gets to be wrong and never earns the pleasure of seeing old evidence mean something new.
 - **It is Havenbay-flavoured rather than Havenbay-dependent.** The Rusty Anchor is the crime scene, but a scene is a setting. Nothing yet is a fact about this city, its tides, its records or its memory, that changes the answer. The mooring ledger is the obvious candidate and is not doing that work.
 - **The coin is carrying the season notch** when the real fact underneath it, that somebody was paying for silence in 1989, is stronger and more specific.
 - **Ally is missing two beats she is supposed to have in every episode:** a moment of warmth that costs her something, which is currently Mo's warmth rather than hers, and a change in herself that cannot be undone by the ending.
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STORY TWO — "The Overnight Girl"

Fifteen leads across two phases · lead-state clock, the hunter moves when the player moves · heaviest art bill of the three

What actually happened

A customs clerk at the harbour started photographing manifests. He was not a whistleblower by temperament, he was a man who noticed a pattern and could not stop noticing it, and his wife thought the late nights and the secrecy meant an affair.

Two men put him in the fish-market ice store on a Wednesday night. Nina Vasquez, working the overnight counter at the diner across the way, watched them do it through the window.

Nina understood immediately what having seen it meant, because she has understood that since she was nine. Her family ran from something once before and it left her with a permanent, quiet assumption that they might have to run again. So there is a plan. There has always been a plan. Her brother learned the phone code the way other children learn a times table, and the code has one rule: two rings means safe, and if it ever rings once, you call Ally Quinn and you say the diner, the ice store, run.

At three twelve in the morning, it rang once.

Phase one — the switch, the body, the list

The boy's voice is the first thing in the episode and the reason it works. He is not frightened on the recording. He is *rehearsed*, which is worse.

The first decision is what happens to him. Hand him to Del and he goes into care, formally, safely, and Ally loses the only person alive who can read her sister's code, which makes the rest of the episode measurably harder. Or park him with Helen Quinn, off the books, which keeps him reachable and available, and puts Ally's mother in the path of a man who is working through a list.

The ice store gives up the body. Cortez does the rest. The clerk had a camera, and the manifests he photographed are the reason he is dead.

Then Ally finds the first breadcrumb, and understands what Nina has done: she has left a trail keyed to episodes of the show, because she was a listener, and the only person she trusted enough to leave a trail for was the woman on the radio she had never met.

And then the shape of the episode arrives, three times. At three separate points the board offers two open doors and the case offers time for one. The aunt in the trailer park, or the pawn shop that took Nina's phone. The night bus driver, or the church that runs the food bank. The clerk's widow, or the caseworker who knew Nina when she was nine.

Whichever door is not taken becomes a card on the evidence board that says, in effect, *he got here first*. The person will not talk now. The thing they were holding is gone. The trail still tells Ally something, because it is the hunter's own path drawn in the negative, but the evidence is lost and the endgame gets harder.

Phase one closes with the hunter sitting at the diner counter during Ally's stakeout, ordering coffee, paying exact change. He does not threaten her. He says she does good work, thorough, and that *he* appreciates thorough. He leaves a tip. Exact change again. The scene is polite the way a scalpel is clean.

Phase two — the trail, burned or followed

The fourth decision is whether to use the show. Broadcast the key to Nina's breadcrumbs and the tip line floods: listeners start decoding faster than Ally can, two whole leads arrive free, and the subscriber count jumps. The hunter is listening too, so the next time two doors are open, only one of them still is. He has already been through the other. Or decode quietly, which means doing the archive work alone, at higher cost, in exchange for staying invisible for one more day.

The caseworker, if the player reached her, explains why a nine-year-old had a plan. The widow, if the player reached her, is the grief of the episode: a woman who spent four months believing her husband was betraying her and now has to hold the fact that he was doing the bravest thing he ever did.

The manifests point at a Thursday tide out of Pier 13, circled by hand.

The last decision is whether to go now. The marsh boathouse is the likely place. Likely is not certain. Go now, and skip a lead, and arrive at the ambiguous version. Spend one more lead making sure, and arrive certain, and take him cleanly.

How it ends, and why the ending is not a menu

The ending is not chosen. It is counted. It depends on how many of those three doors the player got through first.

Three out of three. Ally reaches the boathouse before he does. Nina is calm, and she is calm because for the first time in her life somebody kept up with her.

Two out of three. Ally arrives during. He is already there. Del is four minutes away and four minutes is a long time.

One or none. Nina saves herself, exactly as she has planned to since she was nine years old, and Ally arrives to a woman who did not need her. It is the humblest version of the ending and it is probably the best one to have written.

The hunter is taken and gives nothing: hired, layered, a receipt rather than a reason. The manifests point at a company that dissolves the moment Del's warrant touches it.

Nina records one line for the show. *Two rings tonight.*

Then, somewhere else entirely, on a desk photographed in a manifest, a telephone rings twice. Somebody else has learned her code.

What it costs

Ally, Del, Gerald, Mo and the Tip Line exist. Everything else is new: Nina needs a full character sheet because she survives into the series as a caller and an ally, the hunter needs his entrance done properly with the antagonist lighting grammar, the boy needs at least a frame or a voice, the widow is episode-level, and Cortez needs the same portrait Story One needs. At least two new backgrounds, the ice store at night and the marsh boathouse. **Heaviest art bill in the pack.**

What this story does not have yet

- **It is the least Havenbay of the three, and that is the sharpest thing against it.** The escape network is personal, not civic. No tide, no fog, no harbour geometry, no transport pattern, no dockside memory changes what can be seen, proved or reached. Lift this story out of Havenbay and it survives intact, which is exactly what a good case should not do.
 - **The evidence engine is a promise rather than a mechanism.** "The merge requirements are the decoding" says what it wants to be. It does not say what the player physically puts back together, what that lets them conclude, or what the conclusion unlocks. The other two stories can answer that question line by line.
 - **Nobody is named as having benefited.** The hunter is hired and layered. The company dissolves. The episode ends with a professional in custody and nobody to be angry at.
 - **There is nothing Ally believes and has to abandon.**
 - **The grief is split three ways.** The dead man's widow carries the mourning, Nina carries the danger, and the brother carries the feeling. Three strands and none of them is the spine. The other two stories concentrate grief in one person.
 - **Ally is missing the same two beats:** no warmth that costs her, and no irreversible change.
 - **It puts a crime scene next door to the tutorial.** The diner is Del's table, the food generator, and a room the game teaches in during week one. Making it crime-adjacent immediately is a tonal cost that should be paid deliberately or not at all.
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STORY THREE — "The Last Caller"

Eighteen leads across three phases · day-stamped clock · middle art bill, but it currently fails the branching budget

What actually happened

The same 1989 death sits under this story as under the first: a man went into the harbour at the foundry basin, and it was called a fall, and it was not one. The difference is who is telling you.

An old man, dying, decides to spend the last thing he owns. He writes it down first, because he does not trust himself to say it straight. Then he rings a tip line at four minutes past midnight and reads it aloud: the year, the basin, the lie, and the fact that he was paid to tell it.

He gets as far as *there was a witness, she was nine years old, her name is* and a hand comes over the receiver.

Four seconds of a room with two people breathing in it. Then dial tone.

That is the horror of this story and it is worth being precise about why. Somebody was standing beside him. Somebody let him confess to a murder, on tape, at length, and stopped him at exactly one sentence. Whoever it was does not care that the crime is known. They care that she is named.

Phase one — the tape and the body

Ally has a voice and no name. What she has instead is forty seconds of a room, and the show is very good at rooms.

The first decision is what she puts on air, and she can only use two of three things. The interval of a foghorn behind him, which places him geographically. The rattle of a prescription bottle, which places him medically. Or the sentence *I was paid to say it was*, which places him morally and is the one that travels.

Each one that airs brings someone forward in the second phase. A harbour pilot who can name the foghorn. A pharmacist who knows the rattle. And the third, which reaches the wrong ears entirely and moves the person who covered that receiver one step closer to the woman they are both looking for.

Whatever Ally does not broadcast, she has to work out the hard way, alone, at cost.

By morning the caller is dead. Cortez proves it was not natural. He was going to die anyway, within months, and somebody could not wait months.

The second decision is whether to name him on air. Naming him opens the 1989 file faster, because Arthur Finch can go straight at an archive with a name in it, and a whole lead's work comes free. Protecting his family keeps them talking, and they hand over his coat, and sewn into the lining is a brass coin with one face worn blank, which arrives two phases earlier than it otherwise would.

Phase two — nineteen eighty-nine, and the hunt for her

The 1989 basin death comes up out of the Gazette's archive. The inquest, the witnesses, the closing. And in the margin of it, a school class register.

She was nine. The city's records will tell you every girl who was nine that year within half a mile of the foundry basin. Three of them fit everything Ally knows.

The third decision is which of the three she goes to first, and this is the best beat in the entire pack. It is not a menu, it is a deduction with a cost. Choosing wrong is not a failure state: the woman who was not the witness was in the same class as the woman who was, and she produces the school photograph that makes the right identification possible. But it costs a phase tick, and a phase tick is ground given to somebody else who is also looking.

There is also an optional piece of work most players will skip. Those four seconds of room tone at 12:04, with two people breathing in them, can be analysed properly. It takes a whole lead. Do it, and the arrest at the end is airtight and the man in custody gives up the chain above him, which is the deepest season revelation available in this story. Skip it, and the arrest still holds and the next episode simply opens with less.

She is found at the end of the second phase, and she has been findable the whole time, which is the thought the episode wants to leave in the player's head.

Phase three — what she saw finishes the sentence

She will not testify on somebody else's schedule. She has spent thirty-seven years not being asked and she is not going to be hurried now.

The fourth decision is the one the story is built around. Hold the episode until the arrest, which keeps her safe and slow and means the case has to be made without any public pressure at all. Or publish, and let the episode be the pressure, and accept that the man who covered a receiver at midnight will hear it at the same moment everybody else does.

Both roads reach the arrest. The proxy is an episode-level face, hired, careful, and eventually careless.

The last decision is the promise. The tip line keeps voices, timestamps and nothing else. Ally has said it in every episode she has ever recorded. The 12:04 tape is the single strongest piece of evidence in the case, and handing it to Havenbay PD breaks the promise in public.

Break it, and the case is materially stronger, and the tip line goes quiet in the next episode: fewer people call an anonymous line that turned out not to be. Keep it, and the case is weaker, and the show stays what it was.

How it ends

The sentence gets finished. A woman who has been a witness since she was nine years old stops being one and becomes a person who told.

What remains is the thing nobody explains: somebody stood in a room and permitted a confession right up to the name. Not the crime. The name.

What it costs

Between the other two. The caller is voice-only, like Doyle, which is the cheapest and most thematically apt victim design available. The witness needs one full character sheet. Cortez needs the portrait both other stories need. The proxy is episode-level. Backgrounds: the foundry basin, which Story One would also use, and one master for the witness's inland town.

But it currently fails the branching budget, and this is not a small note. The rule is at most one fully exclusive branch per episode. This story has two: the three candidate women, and the hold-or-publish chain. The fix is to demote the candidates to evidence only, with no scenes, which keeps the deduction and removes the drama from it.

Which means: this story's best feature is the thing that makes it unaffordable. That is worth knowing before choosing it, and worth solving rather than ignoring.

What this story does not have yet

- **It fails the branching cost ceiling**, as above, and the obvious fix costs it the beat that makes it special.
 - **The most important character in it does not appear until the final phase.** A woman the player has never met cannot carry two thirds of an episode. The intended solution is to have her present the whole time as objects: a school photograph, her handwriting on a register, her voice on a 1989 recording, her name almost said by three separate people. That solution is designed and not built, and if it gets dropped under schedule pressure the ending lands on a stranger.
 - **Nobody has a face at 12:04.** The story admits this itself: the presence in the room needs an identity eventually, and it cannot be a season villain.
 - **There is no wrong hypothesis**, although the three-candidate structure comes closer to one than anything else in the pack. It is the cheapest place in the whole slate to put a real false trail.
 - **The shape is familiar, and that is the serious objection.** An interrupted recording is reconstructed in order to find a woman. That is the shape of the pilot twelve testers abandoned. Putting a murder in the first minute changes the stakes and does not change the shape, and the surface is what a listener meets first.
 - **Havenbay identifies, but it does not decide.** The foghorn interval is the best location detail in the pack and it is used to work out where a man was sitting, not to change what the answer is.
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A note on what happens next

Two of these three will not be built as Episode 1, and one of the two that lose cannot be built at all, because The Confession and The Last Caller share a 1989 spine and cannot both be true. The Overnight Girl banks cleanly alongside either.

Whichever wins, the same work follows: the structural gaps listed under each story get fixed once, on the winner, in a lead-by-lead pass that also regenerates the economy for a longer episode and produces the art and voice manifest.

And nothing above decides it. Five or more of the twelve people who abandoned the last pilot hear these three openings read aloud, cold, without titles, in a rotated order, and answer two questions.

Which one do you need to hear the rest of.

Would you come back tomorrow for it.

Draft register throughout. Every quoted line follows the house rules and none of it is locked; all copy goes through line-by-line ruling at script pass.